EWF Wrestling Manager

The full picture: review, plans and ideas

Everything from the 17 October 2026 session in one place: the add-ons work done, the concept art, a full review of the game, the road to A+ in every area, the first-month guide, story mode, the stat trim, the playtest plan, and characters with backstories.

17 October 2026 | Version 0.85 | Branch claude/awesome-lovelace-qb0f2j

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2	The game today: a full review with grades and screenshots at 1080p
3	The road to A+: every area, the order of work, the first-month guide, story mode, the stat trim, the playtest
4	Characters with backstories: an original world, motives that drive storylines, World Editor history tools

Part 1: The session in short

What was done, what was drawn, and what needs a decision.

What was built and pushed

- **Venue personality and disasters (add-ons item 12, version 0.85).** Every building has its own feel, sound, crowd and sightlines, which lift or dampen the crowd. Now and then trouble strikes before the first match (power, ring, weather, a fight in the crowd) as a call from the gorilla position, each answer with its price. Tests pass; the scenario reference was renewed.
- **Earlier in the add-ons run:** balance fixes, version tracking, the build-order check, career saves, scenarios as data, the kayfabe layer, journalists, the writers' room and post-mortems (Phases 0 to 2).
- **Not published** to the live page, as the add-ons brief asked.
- **Documents** in docs/plans: next week's plan, the game review, the road to A+, the characters plan, and this combined report.

The concept art

All boards are on one canvas: claude.ai/artifact/9vtkC1f1mzGnv866j99xbc.

Row	What it explored	Verdict
1. Retro ideas (1280×720)	Sparklines, heat strips, a map overlay, roster cards, a title change in lights.	Good ideas, kept for later rows.
2. Arena style (1280×720)	A dark, modern TV-broadcast look with poster type.	Pops, but drops Ryan's chosen look.
3. Hybrid (1920×1080)	The grey windows with modern hierarchy and lights.	A good bridge.
4. Redesigns of today's desk (1920×1080)	1: Sharper desk. 2: Marquee night (the show as a sign in lights). 3: Control room (the map is the hero).	Pick 2 for pop, or 1 to stay close to today.

Every decision waiting for Ryan

1. The desk look (Redesign 1 or 2), and design at 1080p while keeping 1280×720 working.
2. The guide character: the Timekeeper, the road agent, or another idea.
3. The first-month guide, on and recommended for a first game.
4. Story mode: ten years, beats not scenes, one year at a time.
5. The stat trim on screen first, engine untouched.
6. Run the first-hour playtest before building the guide.
7. A cap on interruptions a week, and how many.
8. An original default world with backstories; what happens to the parody world (keep, separate download, retire).
9. The ten traits, and how many hand-written stars.
10. The licence, and whether to rewrite git history for the old parody notes.
11. Wording for player-made worlds and Workshop rules (for the lawyer).
12. Publish the add-ons work to the live page now, or after the run.

The first three things to do

1. Fix Suggest a card in the parody world (it fails for 4 of 9 companies, including the starting one, within a year).
2. Fix the two failing tests (test-cancel, test-events).
3. Ryan answers the decisions above, starting with the desk look.

Part 2: The game today

A full review: systems, stability, balance, screens, code, content and Steam readiness.

The verdict

The game is deep, and the simulation is solid. Few games in this genre have this many interlocking systems: living feuds, a relationship memory, a live show with calls from the gorilla position, the road, the press, the writers' room and post-mortems. The engine is repeatable and well tested.

The biggest problems are not features. They are:

- **The default world can't fill a show.** In the parody world, the one a new game starts in, Suggest a card fails for 4 of 9 companies within a year, including EWE, the company you start as.
- **The screens don't use a big screen.** At 1080p they waste space and cut text short.
- **Hard to learn.** The game is deep enough that a new player will struggle to see what matters.

Area	Grade	In one line
Depth of the simulation	A	Over 40 systems that feed each other through people and memory.
Stability	B	No crashes or bad numbers. 2 old test failures, and the parody card problem.
Testing	A-	41 headless and 38 browser tests, a repeatability check, a build-order check.
Balance	C+	Better since 0.73. The big company is still fired on 2 of 3 runs, and two models go broke.
Screens and readability	B-	Clear 90s look that fits. Small text, cut-off lines, empty space at 1080p.
Learning the game	C	Many terms (BP, AP, heat, freshness, market) and little guided teaching.
Code health	B	Clear rules and hooks. Very dense lines, one shared scope, some files getting big.
Content and legal	B	Two original worlds and a parody disclaimer. No licence chosen; old notes still in git history.
Ready for Steam	C	Plays in a browser today. The wrapper, store page, achievements and settings still need work.

The game in numbers

84	**86**	**79**	**2.4 MB**

engine files, about 13,000 lines (1.2 MB of code)	screen files, about 7,700 lines	automated tests (41 headless, 38 browser)	the whole game in one HTML file
1.5 s from opening the page to a playable desk	**2** worlds: parody (9 companies) and public domain	**135 / 240** items done in TASKS.md (105 open)	**100 / 100** TWEAKS done; WISHLIST 100 of 101 done

What the player does

A week has three parts, and each hands the next something unresolved:

Phase	What happens	What it hands on
The Office	The desk shows the road (the city, the building, tickets sold), matters to answer, this week's tasks and the next show. Backstage is people who need you, each with a file and a memory of you. Storylines holds living feuds and the plot actions you can spend booking power on.	A fire with a deadline, and people in a mood.
Booking	Fill two or three hours with matches, promos and angles. The road agent reads each match without saying too much. Running order, chemistry, fatigue and promises all matter.	A card with visible risks.
The Show	Played on the air step by step. The gorilla position takes calls: injuries, a quiet crowd, the owner, the network, sponsors, and now trouble in the building. Then After the show gives the grade, the verdict and what the night left behind.	A new problem or chance for next week.

The systems

Group	Systems
People	Relationship matrix and memories, backstage as people, dossiers, requests at your door, scenes between two people, mood, stress, the locker room, the mutiny clock, teachers and students, a champion's friends, hometowns.
Stories	Living feuds (heat and freshness), story sifting, company arcs, debuts, battle royals, the writers' room, promo words written from real history.
The show	The live show and calls, the running order, the show clock, segments, fog of war and the road agent, card flags, venues and disasters.
Business	The road with markets and ticket sales, TV shows with standing and deals, network tastes and executives, streaming, sponsors, contracts with clauses, cancellation, big events with names, head-to-head nights.
The world	Rival companies, invasions and working deals, shows and belts made during a game, a world's history, the press and leaks (kayfabe), post-mortems, archived career saves.
Tools	The World Editor, the logo creator, scenarios as data, two built-in worlds, modding documents.

> **Watch:** each new system adds calls, matters and notes, and they all compete for the same desk. Without a rule for how many interruptions a week may carry, the game risks feeling busy rather than deep.

Stability and tests

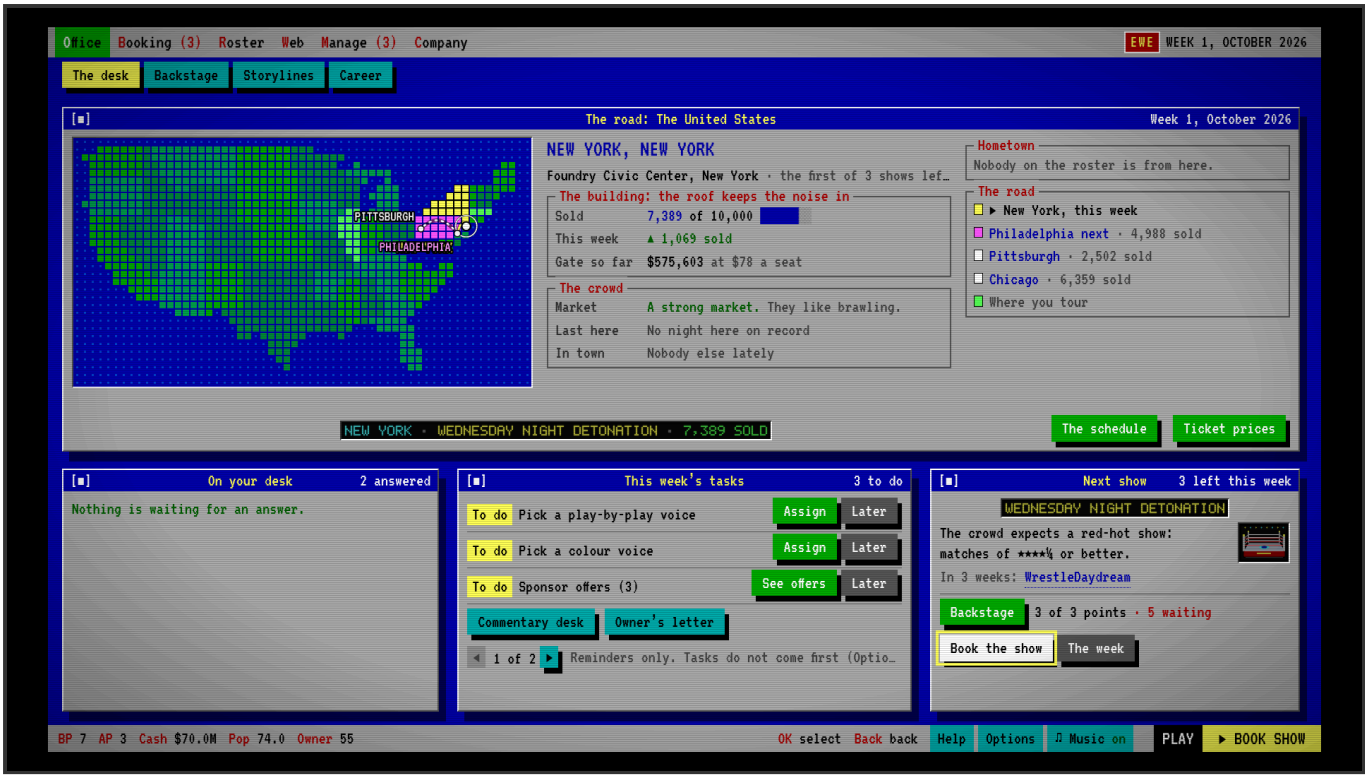
Check	Result	Notes
Headless test suite (41)	**39 / 41**	**test-cancel:** a strong run of house shows no longer brings a network offer. **test-events:** no tournament winner is promised the flagship. Both were already failing before this week's changes.
Same seed, same game	**Pass**	Every game can be replayed exactly.
No dice wording	**Pass**	60 weeks of text checked.
Public-domain world, 60 weeks	**Pass**	No errors, no bad numbers.
Parody world (the default), 60 weeks	**4 fail**	Suggest a card leaves an invalid card for EWE, AYY, CALL and ARK between weeks 48 and 60. No crashes or bad numbers, but **the starting company cannot always book itself.**
Main pages at 1920×1080	**Pass**	Desk, Backstage, Storylines, Booking, Roster, Overview, Web and Manage all fit without scrolling. No console errors.

Balance

From the 100-week balance runs on suggested cards (docs/balance-0.73.txt):

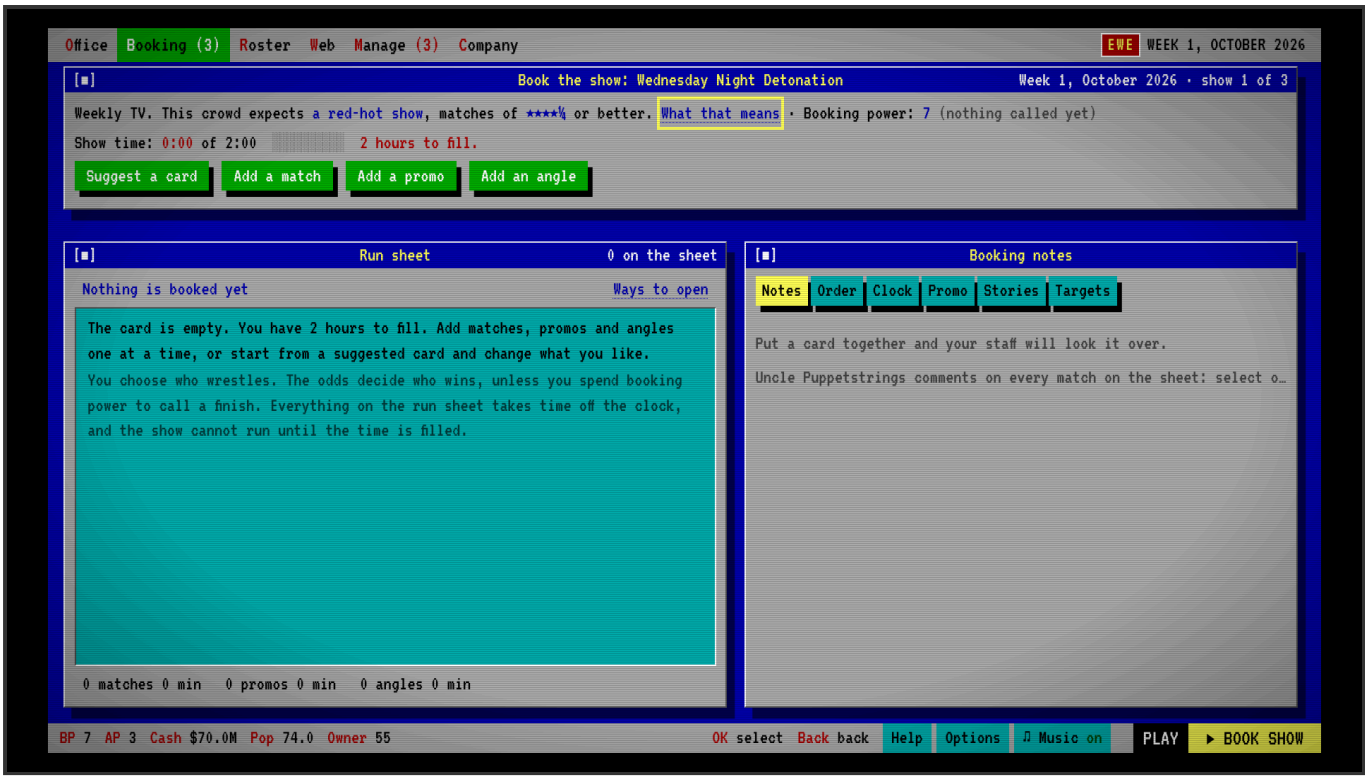
- **Better:** the giant no longer grows to $400M. The underdog survives 100 weeks on all three seeds. The mutiny meeting no longer comes back every few weeks.
- **Still off:** the giant's booker is fired on 2 of 3 seeds. The workrate and outlaw companies go broke on one seed each. The startup is too easy once it gets a better TV slot (about +$470K a week).
- **Crowd against expectation** sits below zero for every company (−0.05 to −1.84). Suggested cards rarely please a crowd, so the player's own booking has room to shine. Too far below and the game feels harsh.

The screens at 1080p



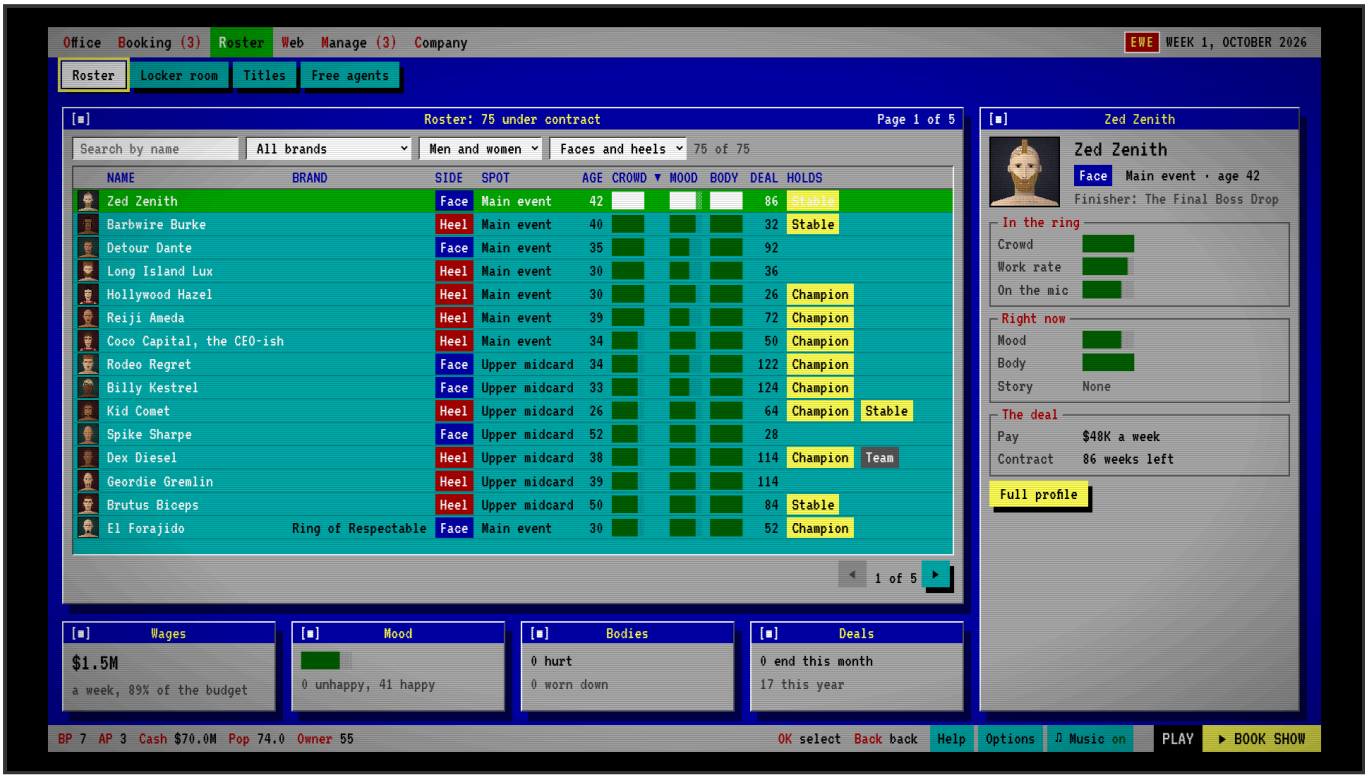
The desk at 1920×1080, parody world, week 1.

- **Works:** the road window is the clear centre, the dot map reads at a glance, the ticker in lights gives the show presence, and the SPACE key always says what's next.
- **Wasted space:** a black border around the whole page (the TV safe area), an empty band under the road window, and "On your desk" mostly empty when nothing waits.
- **Cut-off text:** "the first of 3 shows lef…" and "Reminders only. Tasks do not come first (Optio…". Lines that cut off at 1080p will cut off more at 720p.
- **Weak contrast:** the sold bar is dark blue on grey, and the red first letters in the menu are hard to read.



Book the show, before anything is booked.

- **Empty state:** two thirds of the screen is an empty teal box and an empty notes pane. The best first move, Suggest a card, is one small button among four.
- **Wording:** "The odds decide who wins" sits close to the no-dice rule. Words like "the attempt" or "how the match plays out" fit the game's own language better.



The roster: 75 under contract, 15 to a page.

- **Bars without meaning:** Crowd, Mood and Body are nearly all full green, so the table doesn't help you compare. A short word or a wider range of colour would.

- **Contrast:** a yellow "Stable" tag on the green picked line can't be read. The picked row's bars turn white.
- **Room:** at 1080p there's space for 20 or more rows instead of 15. The Brand column is almost always empty.

Learning the game

- **Words a new player must learn early:** BP, AP, heat, freshness, market, standing, crowd score, booking power, action points, attempts. The bottom line uses the short forms.
- **Help exists** (F1, the owner's letter, required first-year actions) but it's text-heavy. Nothing walks a new player through the first week by doing it.
- **Suggestion:** a guided first week. The owner's letter points to the desk, the desk to Backstage, then Suggest a card, the show and After the show, each with one sentence and a highlighted button.

Code health

Strength	Detail
Clear rules	The engine owns the game, screens never write to the state, hooks for every system, CLAUDE.md as a map.
Repeatable	A seeded generator and hashes, so saves and bug reports can be replayed.
Checked order	A test now makes sure a file that wraps another's functions loads after it.

Risk	Detail
Very dense code	13,000 lines hold 1.2 MB, about 90 characters a line, and 166 lines run past 300 characters. That's hard for a person to read or review, and diffs are hard to follow.
One shared scope	Every engine file shares one closure, and later files rewrite earlier functions. It's powerful, but the more wraps there are, the harder it is to know what a function does.
Hooks everywhere	Many systems push onto the same weekly and show hooks. The order they run in is the file order, which is easy to break by renaming a file.
Save size	About 1.2 MB a save after 100 weeks. The yearly archive keeps 30 years near 3 MB.

Content and legal

- **Two worlds:** parody (the default since 16 October) and public domain, plus a World Editor and modding guide.
- **Open:** no licence chosen (decisions-needed.md lists four options). The notes on who each parody character is were moved out of the repository, but **git history still holds them**. Removing them means rewriting history, which is Ryan's call.
- **Before release:** have the lawyer review the parody world and the disclaimer once more against the final names.

Ready for Steam?

Item	State	Notes
Runs on desk, tablet, TV	Yes	Tested at three sizes. Keyboard, mouse, touch and gamepad.
Saves	Mostly	IndexedDB with a backup copy. A desktop build should save to files the player can see and back up.
Desktop wrapper	Started	An Electron package exists at the root. Not part of the test runs.
Licence, credits, store page	No	Needed before release.
Achievements, cloud saves	No	Optional, but expected by Steam players of management games.

What to do, in order

#	Do this	Why
1	**Fix Suggest a card in the parody world**	It's the default world and the starting company. A player who leans on suggestions hits an invalid card within a year.
2	**Fix the two failing tests**	Small, and keeps the test suite trusted.
3	**Ryan picks the new desk look and the 1080p approach**	Design at 1080p and let the existing type-size setting scale down to 1280×720.
4	**A readability pass on every one-screen page**	No cut-off lines, no empty bands, words beside every colour, bigger bars that differ.
5	**A guided first week**	The depth is there; new players need a path into it.
6	**A limit on interruptions a week**	So new systems add depth, not noise. Rank matters and calls, show the top few, and let the rest wait.
7	**Finish the add-ons run**	Phase 3: supercards, academy, dynasties. Phase 4: match viewer, sound, leagues, play as a wrestler.
8	**Balance pass**	The giant's firing rate, the two companies that go broke, the startup's easy money.
9	**Release groundwork**	Licence, credits, desktop saves to files, wrapper in the test runs, store page.
10	**Code readability, a little each week**	Break the longest lines when a file is touched anyway. No big rewrite.

Decisions for Ryan

- Which desk look, and design at 1080p while keeping 1280×720 working?
- A guided first week: yes or no?
- A cap on interruptions each week: how many calls and matters?
- Licence: which of the four options?
- Rewrite git history to remove the old parody notes?
- Publish the add-ons work to the live page now, or after the run?

Sources: the repository at version 0.85, the headless suite, a 60-week run of every company in both worlds, docs/balance-0.73.txt, TASKS.md, docs/decisions-needed.md, and screenshots taken in Chromium at 1920×1080. Concept art for the redesign: claude.ai/artifact/9vtkC1f1mzGnv866j99xbc.

Part 3: The road to A+

How to take every area to the top grade, with the guide, story mode, the stat trim and a playtest plan.

Where we are, where we are going

Area	Now	Goal	The one thing that moves it most
Depth of the simulation	A	A+	Story mode: give the depth a ten-year spine.
Testing	A-	A+	Every suite green on both worlds, and the guide and story mode tested end to end.
Stability	B	A+	Fix Suggest a card in the parody world.
Code health	B	A+	Shorter lines and fewer wraps, a little each week.
Content and legal	B	A+	A licence, a clean history and a final legal check.
Screens and readability	B-	A+	The stat trim and a readability pass on every page.
Balance	C+	A+	Clear targets per company model, checked by a test on every build.
Learning the game	C	A+	The first-month guide, built from owner's tasks.
Ready for Steam	C	A+	Desktop saves, achievements, store page, and the wrapper in the tests.

The order of work

One step at a time, each shown to Ryan before the next (rule 9a). Each phase leaves the game better on its own.

Phase 1 Fix	Suggest a card in the parody world. The two failing tests (test-cancel, test-events). Fix the wording "the odds decide who wins".
Phase 2 Clear	The stat trim on screen. A readability pass on every one-screen page. Ryan picks the new desk look and the 1080p approach.
Phase 3 Watch	The first-hour playtest with five new players (plan below). Fix the top problems it finds.
Phase 4 Teach	The first-month guide, built as chapter 1 of story mode.
Phase 5 Grow	Story mode, one year at a time. The add-ons run (Phases 3 and 4) alongside.

Phase 6 Ship	Balance targets, Steam groundwork, a licence, the legal check.

How to reach A+ in every area

Learning the game — C to A+

A+ looks like: a new player books a good first show without opening Help, and by the end of month one can explain heat, the road and the gorilla position in their own words.

- The first-month guide, taught through owner's tasks (section below).
- A switch at the start: on and recommended for a first game, off by default once a save exists.
- Words before numbers everywhere: "Hot", "Worn down", "Strong market".
- Remove short forms from the bottom line (BP and AP become "Booking power" and "Action points" once, then the short forms with a note on hover and focus).
- F1 Help becomes "Ask the Timekeeper": search a word, get one paragraph and a button that takes you there.

How we will know: 4 of 5 playtesters finish week 1 without asking for help; nobody quits in the first 20 minutes.

Screens and readability — B- to A+

A+ looks like: every page reads at arm's length on a TV, nothing is cut off, every colour has a word beside it, and the eye lands on what matters first.

- The stat trim (section below): six meters a wrestler, not fifteen.
- One type scale and one button style in the window kit, set once.
- No cut-off lines: a check added to `fits()` that fails on any text ending in "…".
- Empty states that tell you what to do: the empty run sheet says "Press Suggest a card to start, then change what you like", with that button the biggest on the page.
- Use the room at 1080p: 20 roster rows instead of 15, no empty bands, the safe-area border only on a TV.
- Run the accessibility review on each page: contrast, colour plus word, keyboard and pad focus.

How we will know: zero cut-off lines in the test suite; every page passes contrast; playtesters find the next action in under 5 seconds.

Stability — B to A+

A+ looks like: every company in every world can play ten years on suggested cards with no invalid card, no error and no bad number.

- Fix Suggest a card for brand shows in the parody world (EWE, AYY, CALL, ARK fail between weeks 48 and 60).
- Make test-uni run both worlds for 240 weeks (5 years) in the full suite, not 60.
- A save from every earlier version loads: keep a folder of old saves and a test that loads each.

How we will know: test-uni green on both worlds at 240 weeks; the old-saves test green.

Balance — C+ to A+

A+ looks like: every company is hard in its own way and fair. A good booker always beats Suggest a card; Suggest a card never gets you fired in year one.

- Write targets per model into a test (tools/balance.js already measures them): cash growth, owner trust, weeks survived, crowd against expectation.
- The giant: fired on 2 of 3 seeds. Soften the owner's reaction to middling shows for big companies.
- The workrate and outlaw companies: the two that go broke. Look at their costs against their crowds.
- The startup: too easy once it gets a better slot. Scale the slot's money to the company's size.
- Story mode chapters each get their own target, tested the same way.

How we will know: the balance test passes on 5 seeds for all nine models, every build.

Depth of the simulation — A to A+

A+ looks like: the depth is felt, not just present. Every system shows up in a story the player remembers.

- Story mode gives the systems a reason: a TV deal chapter makes networks matter, a war chapter makes invasions matter.
- A cap on interruptions: rank matters and calls by weight, show the top three a week, let the rest wait or resolve on their own.
- Finish the add-ons run: supercards, academy, dynasties, the match viewer, sound.
- A "how did that happen" line on every result: the post-mortem's chain of causes, one press away.

How we will know: playtesters retell a story from their game ("my champion walked out and I...").

Testing — A- to A+

A+ looks like: every suite green, every new system tested headless and in the browser, and a test for every guide lesson and story chapter.

- Green before anything else: the two failing tests first.
- A one-command full run (npm run test:all) with a summary at the end.
- test-guide.js: a month with the guide on, every lesson fires once and in order. test-story.js: ten years on each chapter's targets.
- Browser: the first week walked with the guide; the cut-off check; the old-saves load.

Code health — B to A+

A+ looks like: a new contributor can find and change a system in an hour.

- Break lines longer than 160 characters whenever a file is touched anyway. No big rewrite.
- When a system wraps a function for the third time, add a proper hook instead.
- Split files over 500 lines (82-wishes.js, 10-match.js) by topic.
- Keep docs/map.md and CLAUDE.md current with each change.

Content and legal — B to A+

A+ looks like: safe to sell, safe to mod.

- Pick a licence: the code all rights reserved, with a permissive licence for world packages so modders can share.
- Decide on rewriting git history to remove the old parody notes.
- A final lawyer's read of the parody world and the disclaimer.
- Story mode writing checked against rule 3 (original content).

Ready for Steam — C to A+

A+ looks like: installs, saves, and feels like a finished PC game.

- Saves as files the player can see, copy and back up, plus Steam Cloud.
- Achievements tied to story beats and career moments (first sell-out, ten-year champion, won a war).
- The desktop wrapper built and smoke-tested in the test runs.
- Store page: screenshots from the new look, a short trailer from the match viewer, the parody disclaimer.
- Credits and a licence screen.

The first-month guide

> **The idea:** the game teaches through jobs, not lectures. The owner gives you a task; the guide walks you through doing it; the owner remembers whether you delivered.

The character: the Timekeeper

The old bell-ringer who has worked every show since 1971. On screen he is the ring bell from the dot-matrix lights (already drawn in the game). The bell rings when he wants your attention. He is original (rule 3), dry, kind, and brief.

- He always points at a real button: a highlight and one or two sentences.
- One tip at a time; the next waits until you have done the thing.
- He never holds up the SPACE key except for the required first actions.
- "Not now" on every tip. "Turn the guide off" in Options.
- He retires at the end of month one, then answers F1 as "Ask the Timekeeper", and comes back once for each brand-new thing.

The switch when a game starts

Element	Copy
Switch label	**First-month guide**
Under it	The Timekeeper walks you through your first four weeks: booking, the show, people and stories. Recommended for your first game.
Choices	**Guide me** / **I've booked before**
Default	Guide me when no save exists; I've booked before otherwise.

Four weeks, four owner's tasks

Week	The owner's task	What the guide walks you through	Hands on to
1 Opening night	"Put on a show this crowd will talk about."	Pick your announcers. Suggest a card, change one match. The show clock. On the air: the first call ("They're not going home"). After the show: the letter grade against this crowd.	A sponsor offer.
2 New blood	"Sign a new wrestler and make the crowd care."	Free agents: read a wrestler in words. The offer: wage, length, clauses. Book a debut: vignettes, a surprise attack or a straight match. After the show: did the crowd take to them?	A veteran jealous of the new signing.
3 People and stories	"Give me a story I'd pay to see."	Someone at your door. An action point spent backstage. Pick the year's storyline arc. Start a feud from Stories waiting. Heat and freshness. A promo for the feud. On the air: "Somebody is hurt".	The first big event, and no face of the company yet.
4 The big night	"Name the face of this company and sell me the big event."	Name the face. Plan a feud's ending for the big night. Three hours on the air, the owner on the headset wanting his favourite. The month in review: what went well and why.	Story mode's year one, or the sandbox.

Sample tips

The Timekeeper: Forty years I've rung that bell. Here's the first rule: the owner pays the bills. Read his letter, then we'll get you on the air. *[Read the letter]*

The Timekeeper: Two hours to fill and nothing on the sheet. Press Suggest a card. Then change one match you don't like. Nobody books it perfect first time. *[Suggest a card]*

The Timekeeper: That B means you gave this crowd what they came for. Beat what they expect and you get an A. Same match in a cold town, different grade. *[Got it]*

The Timekeeper: The boss wants new blood. Free agents is where they wait. Don't hunt for the best number. Look for somebody who suits how you book. *[Open free agents]*

The Timekeeper: Signing them is half of it. Now make the crowd care: a few weeks of vignettes, or a surprise attack on somebody they already know. *[Book a debut]*

Copy rules: one idea per tip, under 40 words, every button names exactly what happens, the same words as the screens ("booking power", "the run sheet").

Story mode: ten years, one beat a year

> **Built as beats, not scenes.** Each chapter is an owner's goal, a turning-point event, and a pass or fail result, written in the existing scenario format. The beat adapts to your game: "your biggest star is unhappy" picks whoever really is your biggest star, and how you treated them sets how hard it gets. The first-month guide is chapter 1, month 1. Sandbox players turn it off and keep the same game.

Year	Chapter	Turning point	The owner's goal
1	The new booker	Your first month, with the guide	Finish the year with the owner's trust
2	Make a star	A raw signing with something special	Build a new main eventer
3	The TV deal	Your deal is up and a rival wants your slot	Win the renewal or a better network
4	Walkout	Your biggest star is unhappy and a rival is calling	Keep them, or replace them before the flagship
5	Stadium show	The owner books a stadium for the flagship	Sell it out
6	War	A rival invades	Win the war, or lose a year
7	New owner	The company is sold; the new owner doubts you	Win over the new boss
8	The old guard	Your veterans are fading	Pass the torch without losing the crowd
9	Number one	The biggest company is within reach	Top the world in popularity
10	Legacy	A retirement match for the face of your first decade	Send a legend out right; judged on the whole career

- **Failing a chapter** does not end the game: the next chapter starts harder (a weaker hand, a less patient owner). Only losing the owner's trust ends it.
- **Built from parts that exist:** scenarios as data, company arcs, owner goals and letters, invasions, network renewals, big events, career saves.
- **Achievements** come from it naturally: one per chapter, plus career moments.
- **Each year** goes to Ryan for a go-ahead before the next is written.

The stat trim

Counted from the code: how often each stat is used by the engine and on the screens. Change the screens first and leave the engine alone, so matches, balance and saves do not change.

Stat	Engine / screens	What to do
Fit (Free agents)	1 / 1 column	**Cut the number.** The road agent says "Suits how you book" or "Won't suit your style".
Loyalty	2 / 0	**Cut.** It does almost nothing.
Charisma and mic	27, 110 / 1, 5	**Merge** into "On the mic".
Brawling, technical, speed, stamina	18 to 27 / about 1	**Hide.** Show a style word and Work rate.
Hardcore	14 / 8	**A tag**, not a number.
Durability, safety, consistency	4 to 11 / 0	**Fold** into a hidden ring risk, felt through Body and the agent.
Star quality	18 / 0	**Fold** into Crowd.
Momentum	180 / 3	**Show as a word**: Hot, Cold, Steady.
Stress	30 / 12	**Fold into Mood** ("on edge").
Potential	53 / 2	**Words, once scouted**: "could be a main eventer".

> **The wrestler card after the trim:** Crowd, Work rate, On the mic, Mood, Body, a style word, momentum in a word, and the deal. Six meters instead of about fifteen. At company level the bottom line keeps cash, popularity and the owner; the rest are said in words where they appear.

The first-hour playtest

> **Goal:** find exactly where new players get lost, before the guide is written, so the guide teaches what people really miss.

Part	Plan
Method	Usability test, watched, no help given. Think aloud. Screen and voice recorded.
Who	5 players: 2 who know wrestling and management games, 2 who know wrestling only, 1 who knows management games only. None has seen the game.
Length	60 minutes each: 5 warm-up, 45 playing, 10 talk afterwards.
Tasks	1. Start a game. 2. Book and run your first show. 3. Answer what is on your desk. 4. Make one wrestler happier. 5. Start a storyline. Then play freely.
Watch for	Where they hesitate over 10 seconds. What they click that does nothing. Words they ask about. When they first smile. Whether they want to play another week.
Ask afterwards	What was the game about? What was confusing? What would you do next week? What did you ignore? Would you buy it?
Make sense of it	Put every observation on a card. Group them by theme (affinity map). Rank by how many players hit it and how hard it is to fix. The top five become the guide's lessons and the first fixes.
Done in	About a week: two days to find players, two days of sessions, one day to sort and report.

Decisions for Ryan

1. The guide character: the Timekeeper, the road agent, or another idea?
2. The first-month guide, on and recommended for a first game: yes?
3. Story mode: ten years, beats not scenes, one year at a time: yes?
4. The stat trim on screen first, engine untouched: yes?
5. Run the first-hour playtest before building the guide: yes?
6. The desk look, and design at 1080p while keeping 1280×720 working?
7. A cap on interruptions a week: how many?
8. The licence, and whether to rewrite git history for the old parody notes.

Built with the frontend-design, user-research and UX-copy skills, on top of the review "The game today" (docs/plans/EWF-game-review.pdf). Stat counts come from the code at version 0.85.

Part 4: Characters with backstories

The plan for an original world whose characters drive their own stories.

17 October 2026. Not started. Nothing here is built until Ryan says go, one step at a time (rule 9a).

The idea in one paragraph

Make the default world original: wrestlers the game invented, each with a backstory it can read. A backstory is data, not flavour text: where they came from, who trained them, what they want, what they fear, who they are tied to, and what they hide. The story systems (story sifting, requests at your door, the writers' room, leaks, company arcs, story mode) then build storylines from real motives instead of numbers. The World Editor gets the tools to write any character with a full history, so a player can build a real-world world for themselves. The game itself never ships real people.

Why

- **Better storylines.** A parody character borrows meaning from a real person the game cannot model. Players expect the real-life arc, the simulation goes somewhere else, and it feels wrong. An original character's story is whatever happens in the game.
- **The game knows why.** "Ambitious, trained by the champion's rival, wants the title before turning 30" gives sifting, requests and the writers a reason. Today they mostly have ratings, mood and records.
- **No legal exception needed.** The parody world was allowed on a lawyer's advice (rule 3). An original world needs no exception.
- **A proven model.** Text wrestling sims have long shipped fictional worlds, and their players build real-world packages themselves.

What exists today

The world format already holds much of this (`docs/modding.md`):

Already there	Where
Gimmick, gimmick category, catchphrase, finisher and its description	each worker
Hometown, debut year, peak years, disposition, style, roles	each worker
Relationships with a type, a strength, ring chemistry and a note	`relationships`
Reigns, famous matches, feuds and moments before the game starts	`history` (loaded by `src/86-history.js`)
Teacher and student (`w.coach`), hometowns, family	the engine

What is missing is the inner life: what a character wants, fears and hides, and their traits. Those are the parts the story systems need most.

Step 1: the backstory block

One optional block on each worker. Anything missing is filled in by the generator (step 3), so old worlds and saves load unchanged (rule 9).

```
"backstory": {
  "origin": "Grew up over his father's gym in a mill town; the gym closed when the mill did.",
  "trained_by": "old_dutch_vance",
  "path": ["indies", "japan", "tv"],
  "traits": ["ambitious", "proud"],
  "wants": { "k": "title", "text": "To hold the top title before he turns 30, the age his father quit." },
  "fears": { "k": "forgotten", "text": "Being the guy people used to talk about." },
  "ties": [ { "who": "kid_comet", "k": "brother" } ],
  "secrets": [ { "k": "hurt", "text": "Has wrestled on a bad knee for two years." } ],
  "defining": [ { "date": "2019-08", "text": "Lost a hair match in front of his home town and walked out of the building in silence." } ]
}
```

Field	What it is	What reads it
`origin`	One or two sentences	The file, promo words, the dirt sheet
`trained_by`	A worker id	Teacher and student (`w.coach`)
`path`	Where their career went	Promo callbacks, rival interest
`traits`	Two or three from a fixed list	How they react to your choices
`wants`	A kind (`title`, `money`, `respect`, `home`, `legacy`, `revenge`, `family`) and a sentence	Requests at your door, sifting, story mode
`fears`	A kind (`forgotten`, `injury`, `replaced`, `failure`) and a sentence	Mood swings, walkouts, leaks
`ties`	Family, best friend, old grudge, mentor	The relationship matrix at the start
`secrets`	A kind and a sentence	The kayfabe layer (leaks)
`defining`	Dated moments	History, promo callbacks

Traits (the fixed list)

Ten to start, each with one clear effect, so a trait always means something:

Trait	What it does
Ambitious	Asks for title shots sooner; a push lifts mood more
Loyal	A rival's offer tempts less; remembers good treatment longer
Hothead	Real heat builds faster; a loss hits mood harder
Proud	Hates losing clean; refuses some finishes
Mentor	Helps young wrestlers grow; works late with them
Showman	Promos land better; the crowd forgives a weak match
Grinder	Recovers from a bad night quickly; asks for little
Party animal	More likely to make trouble on the road
Family first	Asks for time at home; happier booked near their home town
Locker-room leader	Steadies the room; the room follows their mood

A trait changes how a person reacts through `relBump()` and `youRemember()` (rule 9b). It is shown in words in the wrestler's file.

Step 2: storylines that use it

Each story system reads the backstory. Nothing new on screen except better reasons.

System	What it gains
Story sifting (`src/84-sift.js`)	New patterns: the student and the teacher's rival; brothers on opposite sides; an old grudge from the history; a want blocked by another person (both want the same title)
Requests at your door (`src/79-people.js`)	Requests come from wants: a `home` want asks for a show in their town; a `legacy` want asks for a match with a legend
The writers' room (`src/99-writers.js`)	Pitches built from a want or a fear, in the writer's style
Kayfabe (`src/99-kayfabe.js`)	Backstory secrets become secrets the press can find
Promo words (`src/60-grammar.js`)	Callbacks to origin and defining moments
Story mode (planned)	Chapter beats pick the person whose want or fear fits ("Walkout" picks the star whose fear is being replaced)
After the show	"That win meant more: he finally did it in front of his home town"

Step 3: the generator

A seeded generator writes a believable backstory for anyone without one. It uses `h01()` and the world's seed, never `rnd(S)`, so games stay repeatable. It is used for the undercard, free agents and anyone a world leaves blank.

- Picks an origin from region, age and style.

- Picks traits that fit the style and disposition (no dice wording anywhere it is shown).
- Sets a want and a fear that fit the career stage: young wrestlers want a break, veterans want a legacy.
- Ties people who share a home town, a trainer or a team.
- Gives one in four a secret.
- Writes it all through the text grammar (`src/60-grammar.js`), so lines vary and are only used when true.

Step 4: an original world

A new default world with hand-written stars and generated depth.

- 4 to 6 companies with clear identities drawn from the nine company models.
- 30 to 40 hand-written characters at the top: full backstories, ties between them, a history from a few years before the game starts.
- The rest generated (step 3), then checked by hand.
- Original names, places and events throughout (rule 3).
- Built in `universes/<name>/` like the parody world, packed and checked by a tool.

Step 5: the World Editor's history tools

So anyone can write a world with full histories, including a real-world one for their own use.

- A backstory page for each character: every field in step 1, with the trait list and the generator's suggestion one press away.
- A history builder: add reigns, famous matches, feuds, moments and relationships on a timeline with dates.
- Import and export of a character or a whole roster as JSON.
- The engine turns that history into relationships and memories when a game starts, as `src/86-history.js` does today.

Real-world characters made by players

- The game ships no real people. The editor is a tool; what a player builds is theirs.
- A shared world shows a line when it loads: "This world was made by a player. It is not part of the game."
- If worlds are shared through Steam Workshop later, take-down rules and a report button come with it.
- The exact wording and the Workshop rules go past Ryan's lawyer first.

What happens to the parody world

Three options, Ryan's call:

1. **Keep it as an optional world** on the title screen, as it is now, but not the default.
2. **Move it out as a separate download** (a world package), so it is not part of the shipped game.
3. **Retire it.**

Option 2 keeps the work and takes the parody out of what is sold. The lawyer should weigh in.

Tests

- `test-characters.js`: every worker in every world gets a full backstory; generated ones are the same on the same seed; old worlds and saves load; 60 weeks with errs 0 and NaN 0.
- Sifting, requests and the writers' room each produce at least one storyline from a want or a tie in a 60-week run.
- The editor's history builder: build a world with history from nothing, play it, check the relationships and memories it made.
- `test-wording.js` covers generated backstories.

The order

1. The backstory block and traits, shown in the wrestler's file.
2. Sifting, requests and the writers' room read them.
3. The generator.
4. The original world.
5. The World Editor's backstory page and history builder.
6. Ryan picks the default world and what happens to the parody world.

Decisions for Ryan

1. Make an original world the default: yes or no?
2. The parody world: keep, separate download, or retire?
3. The ten traits: add, cut or rename any?
4. How many hand-written stars in the original world (30 to 40 suggested)?
5. The wording for player-made worlds, and Workshop rules, for the lawyer.